

Lila-Josey James

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BIO:

Lila's recent work appears in *Boudin*, 6/26, and she has upcoming work in *The Words Faire*. Lila-Josey is a trans woman living in Brooklyn with her dog Estelle. She enjoys tea parties, getting into trouble for the right reason, and aimless walks.

*You Bark, I Stay*

Word Count: 950

Under the dappled blue light of American Elms, we bleed. Her white acrylics drip apple red delicious just as my bottom lip does. Cigarette smoke twirls in the late summer sun long after the action. I curl my fingers in, and she the sides of her lips.

“You killed the poor flowers.” Inez says.

She glances at the dandelion patch under my right foot. I step back. The weeds are flattened, and as I stare, ruddy dots appear on the wisps. I place two fingers on my busted mouth.

“You’re always just stomping around!” Inez says, poking a cigarette inches from my face.

“Sorry.” I say.

She looks at me with wrinkles and whiskers. Her teeth are bare save for the stains on her canines. The top left being the most discolored of all.

“Thank you.” She says.

Inez exhales a large plume. It stings my eyes. In this haze, I carefully focus, suck my lip, and spit.

In the distance an American robin sings. Its song is sweet and sharp like cranberries. She’s frozen. I stare at her, she at the trees, and the trees at everything. We say nothing.

I leave the groove, and head downhill towards the dog beach. It’s a short walk, and surrounded by people. There’s no sand, only large rocks, pavement, and a few splashing dogs in the pond. Two benches line the walls of the water entry. Turtles pop their heads in and out of the water. I want to keep tabs on canines too.

“You can live with me,” Inez says. “I’ll take care of you.”

If the wind didn't carry it, I doubt I would have heard over the barks and yips. I stay. The best I can do is nothing as she walks down from the Elms. I feel my breasts. The fresh cuts and dissolving sutures. There's a plastic tube going into my superior vena cava. A fancy way to say my heart. I turn to face Inez as she closes in.

The sun still beats at dusk. The whole sky is strange. It's too blue, too bright, and the air which makes it, far too refreshing. The funniest of all being the bulbous peach clouds. Their fluff looks right for the eating.

"You don't love me?" I ask.

There's a pause. One of those that stretches into the years to come. The water is being pulled in before the rush.

"Thank you." She whispers.

She takes my hand, and pulls us right. Leading to a wooded footpath circumnavigating the pond. It's the quickest way from Park Slope to Prospect Leffertes Garden. She's taking me to her neighborhood.

"It's out of the blue." Inez says.

"Not really." I reply. "Especially if you think about it for more than a second."

There's a small waterfall to our right. A wooden bridge spans the narrowest stretch of water.

"You always have loved my body." She says.

Here wrinkles iron out as her eyebrows come down.

"I still do." I say.

The bridge's beams creak as we tip-toe across. Teenagers have jumped the chain-linked fence blocking the forest. They're smoking and carving love letters.

Directly ahead is a paved incline. We're silent but quick as we climb. Not fastening, but keeping the same pace. We labor our breath for the same ease as minutes before.

No direct light enters this part of the forest. Everything is a deep cool green. Even the people have disappeared. We still hear echoes from the bottom of the trail. We stop on the precipice of the tallest hill in Prospect Park. There's a lone bench at its peak.

"We can" I start to offer.

"The thing is," she interrupts. "I'm not into women."

Her extended left index finger isn't even chipped. The garnet red looks designed. Honestly, she's just so damned impressive. I plant my foot down, and throw my hands down.

"And this?" I ask.

"What this?" She replies.

I throw my arms up.

"I offered." She says.

I sit on the edge of the bench. The light becomes heavy like garnets. That cool green turning heavy.

"Why are you even here?" I ask.

"To tell you." She walks up.

"Important enough to be face to face?" I say.

"This is for me." She says.

"Well, there's no this according to you. So, I don't understand." I say "I really can't be your friend right now." I confess.

It's true too. I can walk away. Do less, harm just some. It never works out that way.

"I don't think I can talk to you ever again." She says.

With that Inze turns away. She doesn't pull away all at once. Rather, it's a slow hope like molasses. Her lotioned but callesed hand slides from mine. Our finger tips touch at the end. On instinct, I curl mine. She smiles

"This is really silly." I say.

She keeps walking. Doesn't even bother to turn. I've never been more certain of love. Still, I wait for the command.

As she approaches the bottom, I watch. Everyone is down there. Everything is happening there. In the forest, I bathe in dappled green light. At the opening of the path, a giant grass field rolls. There are dogs running freely. Leads are off.

She stops and pauses. Now I smile. She begins to turn, but stops 45 degrees short. With arm extended, she tosses her cigarette pack in a wooden planked garbage bin. She waits for a few seconds more. A bright figure appears. The setting sun blinding all but silhouettes. They walk off. I stay.

The trees make their own twilight, and the American robin their own song. Now that she isn't barking, the silence comes crushing in.